

Jamiatul Ulama Johannesburg

اللباس الإسلامي للرجال والنساء

Islamic Dress Code for Men & Women

PDF · 18 pages · Shar'ī Requirements



وما علينا إلا البلاغ المبين

"Clear propagation is our only responsibility." — Sūrah Yāsīn 36:17

The Principle of Satr (Concealment)

مبدأ الستر

يا بني آدم قد أنزلنا عليكم لباسا يواري سوآتكم وريشا ولباس التقوى ذلك خير

Allah says: "O children of Adam, We have bestowed upon you clothing to conceal your private parts and as adornment. But the clothing of righteousness — that is best." (Sūrah al-A'rāf 7:26)

The concept of satr (concealment of the 'awrah) is the foundation of Islamic dress. The 'awrah is that part of the body which must be covered with clothing that is loose, opaque, and not resembling the opposite sex or the religious dress of other communities.

Source: Sūrah al-A'rāf 7:26 · Sūrah al-Nūr 24:30-31



The Satr of a Man

عورة الرجل

For a male, the satr (must-be-covered) is from the navel to (and including) the knees. This is the verdict of the Ḥanafī school.

The concealment must meet the following conditions:

1. The cloth must cover the entire area — including the knees themselves.
2. The cloth must not be so tight that it reveals the form (shape) of the satr-e-ghaleez. Skin-tight clothing (tight jeans, tight shorts) breaks this concealment, even if the skin is technically covered.
3. The cloth must not be transparent — the skin colour must not show through.

The Sunnah length of the lower garment (izar/lungi) is to mid-calf. Below the ankle is makrūh tanzīh in the Ḥanafī school, though the Prophet explicitly forbade isbāl (dragging the garment out of pride), which is ḥarām.

Source: Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī 366 · Sunan Abī Dāwūd 4093 · Radd al-Muḥtār



The Satr of a Woman

عورة المرأة

For a free Muslim woman in front of non-maḥram men, the satr is the entire body except the face and the hands (up to and including the wrists). This is the relied-upon (muftā-bih) position of the Ḥanafī school.

The conditions of her concealment:

1. The garment (jilbāb/khimar) must cover the entire body except the face and hands.
2. The garment must be loose — not revealing the shape of the body. Skin-tight "hijab" that outlines the form is contrary to the Sharī requirement.
3. The garment must be opaque — the skin colour must not show through. Sheer fabrics do not fulfil the obligation.
4. The garment must not itself be an adornment (zīnah) that attracts attention. The Sunnah is modesty and concealment.
5. The garment must not resemble the dress of men (tashabbuh) or the religious dress of non-Muslim women.

The face veil (niqāb) is not obligatory according to the relied-upon Ḥanafī position, though it is recommended (mustaḥabb) and was practised by many of the Salaf.

Source: Sūrah al-Nūr 24:31 · Sūrah al-Aḥzāb 33:59 · Radd al-Muḥtār



The Prohibition of Tashabbuh (Imitation)

تحريم التشبه

لعن رسول الله ﷺ المتشبهات بالرجال من النساء والمتشبهين بالنساء من الرجال

The Prophet ﷺ cursed those who imitate the opposite sex: "The Messenger of Allah ﷺ cursed the women who imitate men and the men who imitate women." (Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī 5885)

Likewise, the Prophet ﷺ said: "Whoever imitates a people is one of them." (Sunan Abī Dāwūd 4031, graded ṣaḥīḥ by al-Albānī)

These principles extend beyond mere clothing to behaviour, speech, and presentation. A Muslim's dress should be distinct — recognizably modest, recognizably Muslim, and recognizably conforming to the gender of the wearer.

Source: Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī 5885 · Sunan Abī Dāwūd 4031



The Importance of Loose Garments

أهمية اللباس الفضفاض

A common modern error is to wear "Islamic" clothing that is technically covering the *satr* but is so tight that it reveals the form. This is contrary to the Sharʿī requirement.

The Ḥanafī fuqahā have explicitly stated that the concealment of the *satr* requires that the form (*shakl*) of the *satr-e-ghaleez* not be revealed. Tight jeans, tight T-shirts, tight "abāyas" that outline the body — all of these fail the Sharʿī requirement, even though the skin is technically covered.

The Sunnah attire — a loose *izar/lungi* and a loose *qamīṣ* (*kurta*) for men; a loose *jilbāb* and *khimar* for women — is the most complete answer. Loose trousers that cover below the knees with room to spare are acceptable for men, provided they do not resemble *kuffār*-style dress.

Source: Radd al-Muḥtār · Al-Durr al-Mukhtār



Practical Guidance

إرشادات عملية

For the Muslim man:

- The lower garment should cover from the navel to below the knee, with looseness.
- A loose qamīṣ (kurta) is Sunnah.
- White clothing is recommended (the Prophet said: "Wear white clothes, for they are the best of your clothes." — Sunan al-Tirmidhī 2810).
- The beard is obligatory (wujoob) according to the Ḥanafī school — to trim it below a fist-length is not permissible.
- The izar (lower garment) above the ankle is Sunnah; below is makrūh tanzīh; dragging out of pride is ḥarām.

For the Muslim woman:

- The garment should cover everything except the face and hands.
- Loose, opaque, non-revealing.
- A black or dark-coloured jilbāb is Sunnah.
- The khimar (head-covering) should cover the head, neck, and chest.
- The garment must not resemble the dress of non-Muslim women or of men.

Source: Sunan al-Tirmidhī 2810 · Fatāwā Hindiyyah



جمعية العلماء جوهانسبرغ

Jamiatul Ulama Johannesburg · Darul Iftā

P.O. Box 961195, Brixton, 2019, Johannesburg · admin@jamiat.joburg

وما علينا إلا البلاغ المبين